

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: China News Service via Getty Images

Chinese state media reported that a gas explosion in a coal mine in northern **Shanxi** province killed at least 90 people. Rescue efforts are still underway. Xi Jinping said that lessons must be learned from the incident, which happened on Friday night. Chinese coal mines once accounted for thousands of deaths every year. However in recent years thousands of mines have been closed and safety has improved, even as [output has increased](#).

Pakistan says its military chief, Asim Munir, has held “highly productive” talks with Iranian leaders in Tehran, resulting in “encouraging progress towards a final understanding” between **America and Iran**. America’s secretary of state, Marco Rubio also said “some progress” had been made. The region has been braced for the possibility of more fighting, after weeks of failed attempts at a [diplomatic solution](#).

SpaceX completed a largely successful test of its next-generation [Starship](#) rocket, which blasted off from southern Texas two days after the company filed [to go public](#). Despite some engine trouble, the spacecraft that nasa wants to use to land astronauts on the moon released 20 mock Starlink satellites, before coming down with an (expected) explosion in the Indian Ocean.

The World Health Organisation raised the threat from the Democratic Republic of Congo's **Ebola outbreak** from “high” to “very high”. The suspected death toll in central Africa has reached 177; a further 750 cases are suspected. Scientists are working on a vaccine for the disease, but it is not expected to be ready for several months.

Vladimir Putin accused **Ukraine** of striking a student-accommodation hall in the occupied east of the country, which he said killed six people. Russia's president vowed retaliation. **Ukraine** claimed it had hit the operational headquarters of a drone unit. Meanwhile, debris from Ukrainian drones started a blaze at a Russian oil terminal in Novorossiysk on the Black Sea, local officials said.

Shein, a **Chinese fast-fashion giant**, acquired **Everlane**, an American clothing-maker, for an undisclosed amount. Everlane, which is \$90m in debt, was once popular for its sustainably made garments and “**radical transparency**”. Many have criticised Shein for taking the opposite approach. The sale has upset some environmentally minded shoppers.

Pope Leo criticised companies who seek “dizzying” profits while also causing serious environmental pollution. The first **American pope** was visiting Acerra, an area near Naples which the European Court of Human Rights ruled last year had failed for decades to protect residents from **toxic-waste dumping**. The pope urged the world to “reject temptations of power and enrichment” linked to “practices that pollute”.

Word of the week: Amorphous silica, the substance that gives opals their shimmer. An Israeli startup wants to blast tiny spheres of it into the stratosphere to dim the sun and **cool the planet**.



Photograph: Getty Images

An epidemic of responsibility shirking

The 79th World Health Assembly, an annual gathering of health officials, concludes on Saturday. This year's theme—treating public health as the “shared responsibility” of all countries—is particularly salient right now. An unusual spate of [hantavirus cases has been confirmed aboard a cruise ship](#). And [Ebola infections](#) have surged in central Africa.

The contrast between the two outbreaks is stark. The [hantavirus could be contained](#) to the passengers on the ship. The Ebola outbreak began in a remote, conflict-ridden corner of the Democratic Republic of Congo and quickly spread. It has killed at least 139 people and is expected to claim thousands more lives unless [urgent, co-ordinated action](#) is taken. Aid cuts and political problems have prevented that happening. Meanwhile, belying the WHA's stated goal, delegates failed to reach an agreement to share disease data and treatments that would help fight outbreaks. Instead, they took shared responsibility for punting the negotiations into next year.



Photograph: Getty Images

A pretender to Real Madrid's crown appears

On Saturday Enrique Riquelme, a Spanish businessman, is set to file his candidacy to run [Real Madrid](#), perhaps the most prestigious job in European football. He is mounting a rare challenge to the reign of Florentino Pérez (pictured), the 79-year-old construction magnate who has been the club's president for most of the past 25 years. Mr Pérez called an unexpected election for the post on May 11th, a day after Real lost 2-0 to Barcelona, giving their great rivals the Spanish league title.

Real Madrid is a member-owned, non-profit organisation. Its future may thus be in the hands of the 100,000-odd people who pay subs of €179 (\$208) a year. Mr Pérez's influence over the club and its fans is great. But some have grown disillusioned with his once-successful strategy of hoovering up individual star players rather than moulding cohesive teams. Some fans have even begun to boo Kylian Mbappé, its highest-paid player.



Photograph: Bella Spurrier

Something to wine about

Fifty years ago this weekend, the great names and noses of French [wine](#) were invited by Steven Spurrier, an English wine merchant, to judge a blind tasting. He hoped to garner publicity for his shop and wine school in Paris. To mark America's bicentennial, Spurrier had tracked down a few bottles from young, unknown producers in Napa Valley, California, and put them alongside celebrated ones from Bordeaux and Burgundy. To the shock of everyone, Napa's wines won.

The [Judgment of Paris](#) was the shot heard round the wine world. Napa's victory had two Nebuchadnezzar-size effects. First, it sparked demand for Californian wine at home and abroad. The volume of exported bottles of American wine more than quintupled between 1975 and 1980. Second, it inspired confidence in "new world" producers, including Argentina and Australia. Some see it as the most consequential event in the wine world ever. Just don't bring it up to the French.



Photograph: Rob Youngson/Netflix

A man's world?

Damien Sachs, a high-powered executive at an advertising agency (played by Sacha Baron Cohen), thinks he has it all. He lives luxuriously, enjoys crass jokes and relishes in belittling his female colleagues. That is, until he hits his head and wakes up in a world where gender roles have flipped. Here Harry Potter is Harriet, brands have names like Burger Queen and Victor's Secret—and Alex Fox (Rosamund Pike), an employee he taunted, is now his boss.

“Ladies First”, released on Netflix this weekend, is a remake of a French comedy called “I Am Not an Easy Man”. But it is not an easy watch. Many scenes feature men being sexually harassed and getting [cosmetic surgery](#)—including penis filler—while women pass wind and eat burgers. An earnest finale, in which Damien realises the error of his ways, jars with the silly (and dated) tale. Even a star-studded cast cannot save “Ladies First” from finishing last.



Photograph: Reuters

Weekend profile: Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's steady hand on the thrusters

Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's president and chief operating officer, has one regret about launching Elon Musk's red Tesla Roadster into space in 2018. "Starman should have been Starmam," she told an audience of women engineers that year, referring to the space-suited mannequin reclining in the driver's seat, and "she should have had a ponytail coming out of her helmet". Mr Musk may be the public face of the firm that this week unveiled plans for the [biggest initial public offering ever](#), but Ms Shotwell is its commander.

When Mr Musk asked her to join [SpaceX](#) in 2002, Ms Shotwell almost turned him down. "It felt really risky," she recalls. Ms Shotwell, a mechanical engineer with a master's degree in applied mathematics and a member of America's National Academy of Engineering, was working at Microcosm, a space startup, and found Mr Musk, then a newcomer to the industry, slightly naive. She thought he was underestimating how much he would have to invest, and wouldn't sign on until he committed at least \$50m. She had another wobble when Mr Musk offered to make her president in 2008. "What an idiot I would have been if I had said no," she reflected, before encouraging her audience to "take risks".

Hers paid off. With Ms Shotwell at the controls, SpaceX has rocketed above established companies and left governments on the launch pad. These days it runs Earth's biggest space programme. Nearly 90% of the mass launched to orbit last year travelled on the firm's pioneering re-usable rockets.

Ms Shotwell is also a skilled saleswoman. She secured a contract to fly cargo to the International Space Station for NASA, which helped secure the startup's financial future. Her skills and personality complement those of Mr Musk. Where the billionaire is abrasive, Ms Shotwell is, in the words of Eric Berger, an author who has followed SpaceX, the "velvet glove". There is, though, no shortage of steel behind her cheery smile.

If the IPO is as stratospherically successful as predicted, Ms Shotwell will have little time to rest on her laurels. SpaceX must make its giant Starship rocket work; build NASA a lunar lander; keep its Starlink satellite-internet business growing; and deliver on its claim that space-based data centres are the future of AI. That is not to mention its long-term goal of putting humans on the Moon and Mars. But after 18 years at the top of the famously demanding company, she seems to have plenty of burn left in her.

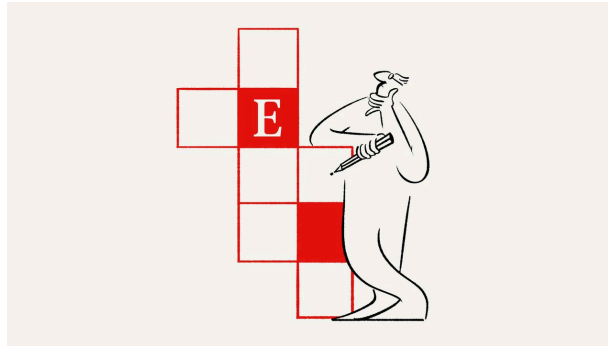


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Add salt to oceans when running (6)

2 across - Tend to throw runes (5)

3 across - Scandinavian minor dictator at heart (6)

1 down - Antagonist misrepresented lack of progress (10)

Straight clues

1 across - Spring; a collection of tv shows (6)

2 across - Caregiver or medic (5)

3 across - Relating to Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway and Sweden (6)

1 down - A period of slow or nonexistent economic growth (10)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Rob Blair, Harare, Zimbabwe

Lorelei Ritchie, Louisville, Kentucky

Ingo Schwanke, Manitoba, Canada

They all gave the correct answers of: Jackie Chan, Bill Gates, the Hollywood sign, Pulp and dogs. The theme is Quentin Tarantino films: Jackie Brown, Kill Bill (vol 1 and 2), Once Upon A Time In Hollywood, Pulp Fiction and Reservoir Dogs.

The questions were:

Monday: Which martial artist from Hong Kong had a Hollywood hit with the film “Rush Hour”?

Tuesday: Who along with his then wife Melinda, founded one of the world's largest charitable foundations in 2000?

Wednesday: Which famous American landmark had the letters “land” removed in 1949?

Thursday: Jarvis Cocker is the lead singer of which Britpop band?

Friday: Pomeranian, Havanese and Sheltie are breeds of which animal?

*Nature provides exceptions to
every rule.*

Margaret Fuller